



A math class in a secret classroom in Afghanistan, where formal education beyond sixth grade has been banned for girls.

Inside Secret Girls’ Schools That Defy Taliban Rules

By ELIAN PELTIER

Ayesha goes to a secret school six days a week, mainly to keep seeing people outside her home. It’s the only way to avoid total isolation under Taliban rule, she says. It’s the only way to feel alive.

“Without that connection,” she said, “I don’t know what would happen to me.”

Now 18, Ayesha once dreamed of studying psychology at university. The Taliban ended that dream when they banned formal education for girls beyond sixth grade in 2022.

But Ayesha has been defying the rules for years, sitting in a classroom hidden behind the corridors of a primary school. Thousands of such programs operate across the country under the Taliban’s radar.



Fifth graders working on an assignment. The only official schools for teenage girls are religious schools.

Clandestine schools were once seen as a stopgap, a way for girls to keep up with their education until the Taliban were gone. But five years after the Taliban’s return to power, nearly 2.5 million Afghan girls have been locked out of secondary school.

They can go to religious schools or study at home with private instruction. But across the country, girls are risking arrest by going to school in secret. Others fail sixth grade on purpose, to remain in their classrooms for as long as possible.

Principals, teachers and parents operate the schools through a clandestine effort, fighting for what they fear may be a lost cause: to save a generation of girls from ignorance. The Taliban’s leaders do not appear willing to rescind the ban, even while

Continued on Page 12

In Prediction Market Fray, States Also Battle Trumps

Administration and Family Business Align on Legal Disputes Over Wagers

By DAVID YAFFE-BELLANY and SHARON LaFRANIERE

In early March, Donald Trump Jr. made a pitch to a crowd of Republican state attorneys general who had gathered for a three-day retreat at the Ritz-Carlton hotel in New Orleans.

Mr. Trump, the president’s eldest son, has repeatedly promised to keep his family’s business interests separate from the work of the administration. But at the closed-door event, he stepped into the middle of a ferocious legal battle over whether states or federal agencies should police prediction markets, a booming new industry in which the Trumps have a financial stake.

Sitting onstage for a question-and-answer session with Montana’s attorney general, Mr. Trump suggested that state leaders were being led astray by a “vested interest” — gambling firms that wanted to protect their “monopolies” by attacking prediction markets, four people familiar with his remarks said. In reality, he said, the markets already had robust oversight, describing them as a sophisticated financial tool overseen by federal officials, not state attorneys general.

Mr. Trump’s tone was friendly, the people said. But his comments, which have not been previously reported, dovetailed with a message his father’s administration has sent to state leaders: Back off.

In lawsuits across the country, red and blue states have united to take on prediction markets like Kalshi and Polymarket, setting up a courtroom battle that will determine whether Americans can use them to bet on sports, politics and virtually everything else.

In total, 20 states are locked in litigation over whether the prediction markets are subject to state laws governing sports betting. Last month, 44 states signed a let-

ter attacking the platforms as a “new form of casino” preying on young people.

State leaders have argued that the markets are dodging regulations and failing to pay state taxes — estimated to total at least \$2 billion a year in lost revenue, according to the Tax Foundation, a non-partisan research group.

The litigation has unleashed an extraordinary blitz of political maneuvering, pitting the federal government against the states. President Trump has declared that he wants prediction markets to



Red and blue states found common ground in lawsuits across the country against prediction markets like Kalshi.

thrive under his leadership, without state oversight. Working side by side with Kalshi, his administration has argued in court that the industry’s sole regulator is the Commodity Futures Trading Commission, a small agency that governs markets for commodities like oil and farm goods.

In the half-century after it was set up in 1974, the C.F.T.C. says, it had never sued a state over regulatory issues. This year, it has sued nine, all led by Democratic

Continued on Page 16

In Election Tie, Luck of Draw Picks Winner

By REIS THEBAULT

GILA BEND, Ariz. — There was an old-fashioned Wild West standoff last week in a onetime frontier outpost.

Two candidates for Town Council in Gila Bend, Ariz., finished with the same number of votes in July’s election, 67 each. A century-old state law mandated breaking the tie with a game of chance.

In this duel, there would be no gunslinging, though there would be a draw — not from a holster, but from a shuffled deck of cards. The hopeful with the higher card would claim the seat.

In an age of increasing distrust in elections and a state that has been a hotbed for voting-related conspiracy theories, Gila Bend’s leaders said they knew the high-stakes tiebreaker, which took place Tuesday, would need to be transparent and carefully choreographed.

“With everything that’s going on, you want it as open as you can possibly get it,” said Patricia Riggs, the town clerk, who oversees elections.

The stalemate in this 1,800-person community, 50 miles southwest of Phoenix, was hardly the first to be decided by chance in a country with tens of thousands of elected local governments and closely divided politics. Races in recent decades have come down to poker games, straw-drawing and, earlier this month in Hawaii, names tucked into plastic eggs

Continued on Page 19

Furor Builds Over Met’s Plan to Honor Designer

By VANESSA FRIEDMAN and JACOB BERNSTEIN

The Metropolitan Museum of Art is facing a growing backlash because of its plan to honor John Galliano, the accomplished British fashion designer who was convicted of a hate crime by a French court in 2011 for his anti-semitic outbursts.

Galliano, who transformed Dior into a global powerhouse before his disgrace, is scheduled to be the subject of a nine-month exhibition sponsored by the Met’s Costume

Critics Cite Galliano’s Antisemitic Tirades

Institute. The show is to kick off with the Met Gala, the annual springtime benefit and red carpet extravaganza overseen by Anna Wintour, Vogue’s global editorial director and a Met trustee.

Amid the public criticism, Met trustees and board members have been scrambling to do damage control. For starters, they are

mulling whether to move the date of the next Met Gala from its usual slot, the first Monday in May, to the week after. In 2027, Yom HaShoah, also known as Holocaust and Heroism Remembrance Day, will fall on the scheduled party date.

In recent days, opposition to the museum’s plan to honor Galliano has grown among Jewish leaders in New York and beyond. Donors have contacted Met executives and threatened to rescind gifts to the museum if the exhibition

Continued on Page 23

Are Creators For Politicians, Or Payments?

By KEN BENSINGER and STUART A. THOMPSON

Josh Greene is a rising left-wing social media star with his own podcast, nearly 800,000 followers and access to politicians like Senator Bernie Sanders of Vermont and Mayor Zohran Mamdani of New York.

He has used that platform to support dozens of progressive candidates in the midterm elections, ranging from low-profile, down-ballot contests to some of the nation’s marquee Democratic primaries. In camera-facing videos, Mr. Greene informs his followers of his preferences, calling some candidates “the most viable” and, in other cases, declaring that “this is the candidate for you.”

He does not always tell his viewers that he is being compensated for his support.

But records show that Mr. Greene, 26, has received money from at least seven politicians, or outside groups supporting them, in the current campaign cycle, including several congressional candidates in New York and a super PAC linked to Dr. Abdul El-Sayed, the Senate nominee in Michigan. Tom Steyer, the former candidate for governor in California, paid him \$21,500.

Mr. Greene, who lives in Southern California and is best known by his handle @joshtheprogresive, is among a growing number of influencers who, at a moment when campaigns are increasingly

Continued on Page 18

U.S. Acquires Venezuelan Oil, President Says

This article is by Rebecca F. El-Liott, Simon Romero and Edward Wong.

President Trump said that the United States had struck a deal to take majority control of a huge portion of Venezuela’s oil reserves, pointing to a sweeping effort to assert U.S. dominance over energy in the Western Hemisphere.

The agreement amounts to a highly unusual foray into another country’s oil fields through a partnership with a private company, the State Department said through a U.S. official.

That firm is affiliated with a Venezuelan businessman, Alejandro Betancourt López, according to two people familiar with the partnership.

The deal would give the United States control of more than 65 billion barrels of proven oil reserves, Mr. Trump said in a social media post on Friday. That is almost as much as all of the proven reserves in the United States, which is the world’s biggest oil producer.

Venezuela’s president, Delcy Rodríguez, said that the “historic” agreement would involve developing 17 oil fields and have a “significant impact on our nation’s revival.”

It would draw more than \$100 billion of investment, she said, and generate an estimated \$209 billion for Venezuela’s strapped government, which has been struggling to improve living conditions after

Continued on Page 10



Unlikely Journey of Luxury Cars Stolen in Canada
Cars are being smuggled through Montreal, above, to meet a booming demand in Russia. Page 8.

INTERNATIONAL 4-14

Turkish-Israeli Tensions Grow
Two powerful U.S. allies and their long-time leaders are locked in a bitter and growing competition in the Middle East and beyond. PAGE 14

NATIONAL 15-23

Deadlier Doses on the Streets
New combinations of ultrapotent drugs are making the nation’s narcotics supply more dangerous than ever. PAGE 15

Uproar Over Privacy Protection
A California bill that intended to defend immigration aid workers became a free-speech cause on the right. PAGE 17

ARTS & LEISURE

Building Los Angeles
Three museums feature the work of Paul Williams, an architect who broke California’s color barrier. PAGE 10

One Day More, and Still More
Regional theaters can once again produce “Les Misérables” because a national tour has ended. PAGE 6



SUNDAY STYLES

Dolly Parton’s Bodacious Flair
As a bedazzled and bewigged entertainer, she was not just going to out-work and out-sing everyone, she was going to out-sparkle them, too. PAGE 6

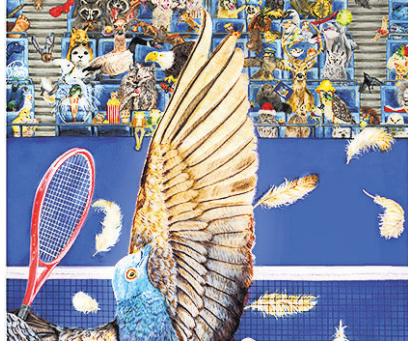
SUNDAY BUSINESS

She Made Economics Popular
But Maria Edgeworth, a 19th-century novelist and a theorist of modern economics, is just getting her due. PAGE 6

Challenging ‘Skill Games’
In Pennsylvania, some gamblers hope the machines, which enjoyed legal protection, will soon go bust. PAGE 1

U.S. OPEN SPECIAL SECTION

Flocking to Flushing
As the summer days start to dwindle, the most free-spirited major tennis tournament gets started in Queens.



METROPOLITAN

A Rise and Fall in Syracuse
The Nob Hill complex was a coveted address. A private equity company bought it, and problems began. PAGE 1

\$250,000 for a Parking Spot
Some New Yorkers are willing to pay condo-like prices for a bit of concrete convenience. PAGE 1

SUNDAY OPINION

William Dalrymple PAGE 6

